

# Network reconstruction approach conditions ecological inference in food web reconstruction

Tanya Strydom <sup>1\*</sup>, Baran Karapınar <sup>2</sup>, Jennifer A. Dunne <sup>3</sup>,  
Pincelli Hull <sup>5</sup>, Crispin T.S. Little <sup>2</sup>, Catalina Pimiento <sup>6</sup>, Andy  
Ridgwell <sup>4</sup>, Andrew P. Beckerman <sup>1</sup>, Alexander Dunhill <sup>2</sup>

<sup>1</sup> School of Biosciences, University of Sheffield, Sheffield, UK, S10 2TN

<sup>2</sup> School of Earth, Environment and Sustainability, University of Leeds, Leeds, UK, LS2 9JT

<sup>3</sup> Santa Fe Institute, 1399 Hyde Park Road, Santa Fe, NM 87501, USA

<sup>4</sup> Department of Earth and Planetary Sciences, University of California, Riverside, CA, USA

<sup>5</sup> Department of Geology and Geophysics, Yale University, New Haven, CT, USA

<sup>6</sup> Department of Paleontology, University of Zurich, Zurich, Switzerland

\*Correspondence: [t.strydom@sheffield.ac.uk](mailto:t.strydom@sheffield.ac.uk)

## Abstract: Aim

Ecological networks are widely used to compare community structure, stability, and responses to disturbance across environmental gradients. However, many networks (particularly those assembled from incomplete interaction data) require model-based reconstruction. We test how alternative reconstruction frameworks condition ecological inference by quantifying their effects on network structure and disturbance dynamics.

## Location

Cleveland Basin, United Kingdom.

## Time period

Toarcian extinction event (Early Jurassic, late Pliensbachian–late Toarcian, ~183 Ma).

## Major taxa studied

Shelly marine macrofossils.

## Methods

We reconstructed four successive assemblages from an identical species pool using six contrasting food web reconstruction approaches spanning feasible (trait-based), realised (allometric and energetic), and structural (topological) network representations. For each community and reconstruction approach, 100 replicate networks were generated. We quantified macro-, meso-, and micro-scale network properties and assessed differences among reconstruction approaches using multivariate analyses. Pairwise interaction turnover was measured using link-based beta diversity. We then simulated species loss under multiple disturbance scenarios, allowing cascading extinctions, and compared predicted community states using mean absolute differences and rank concordance metrics between reconstruction approaches.

## Results

Reconstruction framework strongly influenced inferred network topology, generating distinct structural signatures independent of species composition. Reconstruction approaches that were similar in network metrics often diverged in species-level interactions, with high -turnover among inferred link sets. During extinction simulations, scenario rankings were broadly consistent at the network level, but interaction-level outcomes and cascade dynamics varied substantially.

## Main conclusions

Network reconstruction functions as a structural prior that conditions ecological inference. While some aggregate patterns are robust across reconstruction approaches, detailed interaction-level dynamics are highly contingent on reconstruction approach. Comparative network studies across

spatial or environmental gradients should therefore align reconstruction framework with inferential goals and explicitly evaluate sensitivity to reconstruction assumptions.

**Keywords:** Ecological networks, Biotic interactions, Community assembly, Environmental gradients, Interaction turnover, Trophic organisation, Ecosystem resilience, Macroecology

# 1 Introduction

Understanding how biodiversity is organised across space and time is a central goal of macroecology and biogeography. While early efforts focused primarily on species richness and composition, there is growing recognition that ecological communities are structured not only by which species occur, but by how they interact (Thuiller *et al.*, 2024). Interaction networks are increasingly treated as macroecological state variables where they are used to compare community organisation across environmental gradients, to quantify -diversity in interaction structure, to evaluate stability–complexity relationships, and to infer vulnerability under global change (Poisot *et al.*, 2015; Trøjelsgaard & Olesen, 2016; Tylianakis & Morris, 2017; Gravel *et al.*, 2019).

As a result, ecological networks now play a central role in comparative analyses spanning latitudinal gradients, disturbance regimes, and deep-time environmental transitions (Roopnarine, 2006; Poisot & Gravel, 2014; Michalska-Smith & Allesina, 2019; Dunhill *et al.*, 2024; Hao *et al.*, 2025). Implicit in this expansion is the critical assumption that network properties estimated across systems are structurally comparable, and that differences among them reflect ecological signal rather than methodological artefact (Fründ *et al.*, 2016; Jordano, 2016).

However, most ecological networks are not fully observed as interaction data are incomplete and sampling is uneven across historical and biogeographic contexts, across both present day and deep-time (Poisot *et al.*, 2021; Sandra *et al.*, 2025). Interactions must often be inferred indirectly from traits, phylogeny, body size, co-occurrence, or theoretical constraints (Morales-Castilla *et al.*, 2015; Strydom *et al.*, 2021). Network construction therefore constitutes a model-based inference step rather than a purely descriptive exercise. Different reconstruction frameworks encode distinct ecological assumptions about how interactions arise - whether as biologically feasible combinations of traits, energetically optimised realised diets, or topological structures constrained by macroecological regularities. These assumptions act as structural priors over network architecture (Petchey *et al.*, 2011; Guimarães, 2020; Gauzens *et al.*, 2025; Strydom *et al.*, 2026). If alternative reconstruction approaches systematically generate different trophic configurations, then comparative analyses risk conflating ecological differences among communities with artefacts introduced by reconstruction choice. The reliability of macroecological inference therefore depends not only on ecological data, but on the structural assumptions embedded in network reconstruction.

34 Despite rapid methodological development in interaction inference, few studies have  
35 directly evaluated how alternative reconstruction frameworks condition macroecological  
36 conclusions when applied to the same species pool. This gap is particularly consequential  
37 for comparative research, where network metrics are routinely interpreted as indicators of  
38 environmental filtering, disturbance intensity, evolutionary history, or community stability  
39 (Allesina & Tang, 2012; Poisot *et al.*, 2015; Delmas *et al.*, 2018). If reconstruction  
40 approaches encode distinct structural priors over interaction topology, then differences  
41 among communities may reflect reconstruction assumptions rather than ecological processes.  
42 Consequently, here we test whether macroecological inference derived from ecological  
43 networks is robust to variation in reconstruction framework, asking which aspects of  
44 network-based inference are stable across plausible representations of interaction structure  
45 and which are intrinsically reconstruction approach dependent.

46 Deep-time ecosystems provide an especially stringent test of this issue because interactions  
47 are not observed directly and must be reconstructed explicitly (Roopnarine, 2006; Dunne  
48 *et al.*, 2008; Dunne *et al.*, 2014; Dunhill *et al.*, 2024; Karapınar *et al.*, 2026), rendering  
49 reconstruction approach assumptions transparent. Against this stringency, here we re-  
50 evaluate inferences made by Dunhill *et al.* (2024) on community structure and extinction  
51 dynamics during the Early Toarcian Extinction Event (ETEE; ~183 Ma), a marine biotic  
52 crisis in the Early Jurassic, likely caused by a volcanic-driven hyperthermal event (Kemp  
53 *et al.*, 2024). Crucially, this re-evaluation allows us to test a pivotal but often overlooked  
54 possibility - that the ecological narratives regarding community stability or collapse might  
55 be as much a product of the specific reconstruction method chosen as they are of the fossil  
56 data itself. By applying alternative reconstruction approaches, we can determine if the  
57 Dunhill *et al.* (2024) conclusions remain robust or if a different choice of reconstruction  
58 method would have led to fundamentally different inferences about extinction dynamics.  
59 Using four successive assemblages, we reconstruct ecological networks under six contrasting  
60 reconstruction classes spanning feasible, realised, and structural representations. For each  
61 reconstruction framework, we quantify emergent topology across scales, measure interaction  
62 turnover, and simulate disturbance-driven collapse. By holding species composition  
63 constant while varying the food web reconstruction approach used, this design isolates  
64 the influence of reconstruction constrained structure on inferred food web organisation  
65 and extinction dynamics, allowing us to distinguish ecological signals that are robust from  
66 those that are reconstruction contingent.

## 2 Methods

### 2.1 Study system and fossil data

We used fossil occurrence data from the Cleveland Basin, UK, spanning the upper Pliensbachian to the upper Toarcian. This interval encompasses a major volcanic-driven hyperthermal and marine extinction event. To capture network dynamics across this transition, we defined four successive palaeo-assemblages: pre-extinction (Pliensbachian), post-extinction (Lower Toarcian), early recovery, and late recovery (Middle/Upper Toarcian). Each taxon was characterized using their size and Bambach’s ecospace framework (Bambach *et al.*, 2007), coding for tiering, motility, and feeding mode as per Dunhill *et al.* (2024). Each assemblage was treated as a community of potentially interacting taxa. The dataset includes 57 taxa across diverse groups (*e.g.*, cephalopods, bivalves, and gastropods).

### 2.2 Network reconstruction approaches

#### 2.2.1 Conceptual classification of network types

Most palaeontological research (*e.g.*, Fricke *et al.* (2022); Roopnarine (2006); Shaw *et al.* (2024)) use reconstruction approaches from within the feasibility space. That is, the reconstructions identify and encode the entire feasible diet of a species to build the network. These methods, however, represent only a subset of the broader spectrum of network construction approaches. Here, we present a suite of methods (Table 1) that enable the construction of a wider range of ecological networks and the exploration of a broader set of ecological questions, provided that their underlying assumptions are compatible with the constraints of the data. Along with one feasibility reconstruction approach we include structural models that create species agnostic networks that are structurally ‘correct’ by assigning links between nodes based on assumptions of link distributions; and realised models that create networks where links between species are constrained based on some form of ‘species choice’ *e.g.*, maximising energy gain.

Table 1: Six different network reconstruction approaches that can be used to construct food webs for both this specific community but are also broadly suited to palaeo network prediction. These reconstruction approaches span all facets of the network representation space (feasibility, realised, and structural network) and are suitable for an array of different palaeo-assemblages as the data requirements fall within the limitations set by the fossil record.

| Recon-<br>struction<br>Approach | Assump-<br>tions              | Data<br>needs                              | Limita-<br>tion                                       | Network<br>type | Key<br>reference           | Usage<br>examples                                                                                                                                                                 |
|---------------------------------|-------------------------------|--------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------|-----------------|----------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Random                          | Links<br>assigned<br>randomly | Species<br>richness,<br>number of<br>links | Parameter<br>assump-<br>tions,<br>species<br>agnostic | Structural      | Erdős &<br>Rényi<br>(1959) | Null-<br>model<br>compar-<br>isons;<br>testing<br>whether<br>observed<br>network<br>structure<br>(con-<br>nectance,<br>motifs)<br>deviates<br>from<br>random<br>expecta-<br>tions |

| Reconstruction Approach              | Assumptions                                                             | Data needs                         | Limitation                                                     | Network type | Key reference                                            | Usage examples                                                                    |
|--------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------|--------------|----------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Niche                                | Species ordered along a ‘niche axis’; interactions interval-constrained | Species richness, connectance      | Parameter assumptions, species agnostic                        | Structural   | Williams & Martinez (2008)                               | Evaluating trophic hierarchy and motif structure; baseline structural predictions |
| Allometric diet breadth model (ADBM) | Energy-maximizing predator diets                                        | Body mass, abundance/biomass       | Assumes optimal foraging; does not account for forbidden links | Realised     | Petchey <i>et al.</i> (2008)                             | Predicting realized predator diets; exploring secondary extinctions               |
| Allometric trophic network (ATN)     | Links constrained by body-size ratios and functional response           | Body mass, number of basal species | Assumes only mechanical/energetic constraints                  | Realised     | Brose <i>et al.</i> (2006); Gauzens <i>et al.</i> (2023) | Simulating species loss; evaluating network collapse dynamics                     |

| Recon-<br>struction<br>Approach                   | Assump-<br>tions                                                                                  | Data<br>needs     | Limita-<br>tion                                                           | Network<br>type | Key<br>reference          | Usage<br>examples                                                                               |
|---------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------|---------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Paleo<br>food web<br>inference<br>model<br>(PFIM) | Interac-<br>tions<br>inferred<br>using<br>trait-<br>based<br>mechanis-<br>tic rules               | Feeding<br>traits | Assumes<br>feeding<br>mecha-<br>nisms;<br>trait<br>resolution<br>required | Feasibility     | Shaw <i>et al.</i> (2024) | Mapping<br>feasible<br>trophic in-<br>teractions;<br>assessing<br>secondary<br>extinc-<br>tions |
| Body-size<br>ratio<br>model                       | Probabilis-<br>tic<br>assign-<br>ment of<br>links<br>based on<br>predator-<br>prey size<br>ratios | Body<br>mass      | Does not<br>account<br>for<br>forbidden<br>links                          | Realised        | Rohr <i>et al.</i> (2010) | Estimat-<br>ing likely<br>interac-<br>tions;<br>simulating<br>cascading<br>effects.             |

The three body mass-based approaches (ADBM, ATN, Body-size ratio) differ primarily in their underlying ecological assumptions. Although all three approaches use body mass to infer food web structure, they differ in their ecological assumptions. The ADBM is based on energy maximization under optimal foraging theory, the ATN constrains interactions via mechanically optimal consumer-resource size ratios, and the Body-size ratio model defines links probabilistically within a fixed allometric niche. Together, these approaches span bioenergetic, mechanical, and statistical interpretations of size-structured interactions.

### 2.2.2 Network generation and replication

We evaluated six network reconstruction approaches using the approaches listed in Table 1: Random and Niche models (structural networks); allometric diet breadth (ADBM), allometric trophic network (ATN), and Body-size ratio models (realised networks); and a paleo food web inference model (PFIM; feasibility network). Expanded descriptions

105 of reconstruction approach assumptions, parameterisation, and link-generation rules  
 106 are provided in Supplementary Material S1. For each community, 100 networks were  
 107 generated per reconstruction approach per successive community ( $n = 2400$ ) to capture  
 108 stochastic variation in link assignment. Where reconstruction approaches required species  
 109 body mass or trait values, these were sampled within biologically reasonable ranges to  
 110 preserve relative differences among species. We adopted uniform sampling by default,  
 111 as alternative distributions (lognormal, truncated lognormal) have negligible impact on  
 112 topology (Supplementary Material S2; Figure S1). Structural models were parameterised  
 113 using connectance values drawn from an empirically realistic range ( $0.07 - 0.34$ ), with  
 114 species richness held constant. Identical parameter draws were applied across comparable  
 115 reconstruction approaches within each replicate to ensure comparability. For the Body-size  
 116 ratio model, we followed the approach of Yeakel *et al.* (2014) and excluded the latent trait  
 117 terms.

### 118 **2.3 Network metrics and structural analyses**

119 We quantified network structure using a suite of macro-, meso-, and micro-scale metrics  
 120 Table 2, capturing overall network properties, motif structure, and species-level variability.  
 121 Differences among reconstruction approaches were assessed using a multivariate analysis  
 122 of variance (MANOVA), with reconstruction approach identity as a fixed factor and  
 123 the full set of network metrics as response variables. Variance partitioning was further  
 124 assessed using permutational multivariate analysis of variance (PERMANOVA). Pairwise  
 125 interaction turnover was quantified using link-based  $\beta$ -diversity was calculated following the  
 126 framework of Poisot *et al.* (2012) among the four of the reconstruction frameworks (ADBM,  
 127 ATN, body-size ratio, and PFIM). We excluded the purely structural Random and Niche  
 128 models as they are inherently species agnostic. For each pair of reconstructed networks,  
 129 we represented trophic interactions as binary adjacency matrices and calculated their  
 130 dissimilarity. Specifically we looked at interaction rewiring among shared species ( $\beta_{OS}$ ),  
 131 which allows separation of differences arising from altered interaction identities among  
 132 species common to both networks. All calculations were performed for all reconstruction  
 133 combinations within the same assemblage (time bin).

Table 2: Network properties used for analysis.

| Metric                | Definition                                                                                        | Scale | Reference                                                |
|-----------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------|----------------------------------------------------------|
| Connectance           | $L/S^2$ , where $S$ is the number of species and $L$ the number of links                          | Macro |                                                          |
| Maximum trophic level | Prey-weighted trophic level averaged across taxa                                                  | Macro | Williams & Martinez (2004)                               |
| S1                    | Number of linear chains, normalised by $L/S$                                                      | Meso  | Milo <i>et al.</i> (2002); Stouffer <i>et al.</i> (2007) |
| S2                    | Number of omnivory motifs, normalised by $L/S$                                                    | Meso  | Milo <i>et al.</i> (2002); Stouffer <i>et al.</i> (2007) |
| S4                    | Number of apparent competition motifs, normalised by $L/S$                                        | Meso  | Milo <i>et al.</i> (2002); Stouffer <i>et al.</i> (2007) |
| S5                    | Number of direct competition motifs, normalised by $L/S$                                          | Meso  | Milo <i>et al.</i> (2002); Stouffer <i>et al.</i> (2007) |
| Generality            | Standard deviation of normalised generality of all species within network, normalised by $L/S$    | Micro | Williams & Martinez (2000)                               |
| Vulnerability         | Standard deviation of normalised vulnerability of all species within network, normalised by $L/S$ | Micro | Williams & Martinez (2000)                               |

## 2.4 Extinction simulations and reconstruction approach evaluation

Following Dunhill *et al.* (2024), we simulated species loss from Pre-extinction networks under trait-based, network-position-based, and random removal scenarios. Species were deleted sequentially, with cascading secondary extinctions allowed to propagate. Simulated post-extinction states were compared to observed (*i.e.*, reconstructed from fossil occurrence data) networks using mean absolute differences (MAD) of food web metrics Table 2 and modified true skill statistics (TSS) calculated separately at the node level (species presence/absence) and link level (presence/absence of interactions between species pairs). Scenarios were ranked within each reconstruction framework based on MAD and TSS performance, and Kendall’s rank correlation coefficient ( $\tau$ ) was used to quantify concordance in scenario ordering across reconstruction approaches. Full methodological details are provided in the Supplementary Materials.

## 2.5 Software and Reproducibility

Ecological network reconstruction and extraction of structural metrics were conducted in Julia v1.11.4 (Bezanson *et al.*, 2017). All statistical analyses, model fitting (MANOVA, PERMANOVA, GAMs), and figure production were performed in R v4.5.2 (R Core Team, 2024). The empirical data, derived network datasets and code implementing network reconstruction, extinction simulations, and all analytical workflows are archived at [TODO Zenodo DOI].

## 3 Results

Results show that reconstruction approaches that appear similar when evaluated using network metrics can yield fundamentally different ecological narratives when interrogated at the level of interactions and extinction dynamics. Across six network reconstruction approaches, inferred food web structure, species interactions, and extinction dynamics differed consistently. Multivariate analyses showed pronounced separation among reconstruction approaches in network metric space. Reconstruction approach explained most of the variance in structural properties, leaving a distinct signature independent of community composition. Notably, approaches that were statistically similar in multivariate structural space often diverged in inferred interactions or extinction dynamics. This demonstrates that structural similarity does not guarantee concordance in species-level diets or trophic roles.

Reconstruction approach substantially influenced inferred extinction dynamics. Temporal trajectories of network collapse, interaction loss, and motif reorganisation differed among approaches. Although node-level extinction ranking were often broadly consistent, link-level outcomes and extinction inferences were highly sensitive to reconstruction assumptions. Together, these results show that ecological inferences drawn from networks depend critically on the reconstruction framework employed.

### 3.1 Network structure differs among reconstruction approaches

Across six reconstruction approaches, network structure (network properties listed in Table 2) differed significantly (MANOVA, Pillai’s trace = 3.84, approximate  $F_{40,11955} = 987.35$ ,  $p < 0.001$ ), indicating that reconstruction approach systematically alters inferred food web topology. Canonical discriminant analysis identified two dominant axes of variation, explaining 86% of between reconstruction approach variance. LD1 correlated with vulnerability, direct competition motifs, and connectance. LD2 correlated with maximum trophic level and apparent competition motifs, reflecting vertical trophic structure (Figure 1; Table S1, Figure S1). All higher-order canonical variates each explained less than 9% of the remaining variance.

[Figure 1 about here.]

#### 3.1.1 Variance partitioning of network structure

Permutational multivariate analysis of variance revealed that reconstruction framework accounted for the majority of variation in multivariate network structure ( $R^2 = 0.795$ ,  $p < 0.001$ ), whereas temporal turnover across extinction phases explained a comparatively small proportion of variance ( $R^2 = 0.064$ ,  $p < 0.001$ ). The reconstruction approach  $\times$  time interaction contributed a further 7.1% of variance ( $R^2 = 0.071$ ,  $p < 0.001$ ), indicating limited but significant time-dependent divergence among reconstruction frameworks. Thus, differences among reconstruction approaches were more than an order of magnitude greater than structural differences associated with ecological turnover through the extinction sequence, even if the Pliensbachian-Toarcian dataset was characterised with a significant community turnover.

To determine whether the dominance of the reconstruction framework reflected absolute mean shifts among time bins, we repeated the analysis after centring network metrics within each extinction phase. This procedure removes between-phase differences while

retaining within-phase structural variation. Even after temporal bin-standardised centring, the reconstruction framework explained 84.8% of multivariate variance ( $R^2 = 0.848$ ,  $p < 0.001$ ). These results demonstrate that the influence of reconstruction approach is not driven by temporal mean differences, but reflects intrinsic divergence among reconstruction frameworks in how ecological interactions are organised.

### 3.1.2 Statistical Drivers of Network Variation

To identify which specific structural properties drive the multivariate separation observed above, we partitioned variance at the level of individual network metrics. Results show that reconstruction choice exerted a significantly stronger influence on network topology than the ecological signal of species loss. In panel A of Figure 2 it is clear that for certain network metrics reconstruction approaches predict different responses across time *e.g.*, connectance, as well as differing magnitudes of change *e.g.*, the number of apparent competition motifs. A two-way factorial ANOVA across all eight network metrics confirmed that the reconstruction approach was the dominant driver of variance, with partial eta-squared values ( $\eta_p^2$ ) consistently exceeding 0.82 and reaching 0.97 for meso-scale motifs (Figure 2, panel B; Table S3). While the extinction event (time bin) significantly altered network structure ( $p < 0.001$ ), its relative importance remained secondary, typically explaining a smaller fraction of the total topological variation. This is clear in panel B of Figure 2 where all metrics are within the bottom-right (reconstruction approach-dominated) quadrant of this space, emphasising that framework assumptions outweigh the ecological signal of species loss. Furthermore, the high inter-reconstruction approach Coefficient of Variation (CV) observed for some metrics (Table S4, Figure S4) highlights a sensitivity. The properties that are influenced by time are also those upon which the reconstruction approaches disagree most profoundly. Demonstrating that our understanding of structural food web collapse in the fossil record is highly contingent on the chosen reconstruction framework, particularly when examining complex trophic pathways beyond simple macro-scale properties like connectance.

[Figure 2 about here.]

### 3.1.3 Inferred pairwise interactions vary widely among reconstruction approaches

Despite some network reconstruction approaches showing similar network metrics, specific pairwise interactions often differed. Pairwise  $\beta_{OS}$  revealed that certain reconstruction

228 approach pairs shared very few links Figure 3. Size-based models (ADBM, ATN) were  
 229 broadly similar due to shared sole reliance on body-size constraints, whereas the Body-size  
 230 ratio model exhibited consistently higher differences to other reconstruction approaches.  
 231 PFIM showed intermediate overlap with body mass-based models. These results demon-  
 232 strate that agreement in overall network structure does not guarantee concordance in  
 233 species-level interactions.

234 [Figure 3 about here.]

### 235 **3.2 Reconstruction approach choice influences inferred extinction** 236 **dynamics**

237 To evaluate how reconstruction approach choice affects inferred extinction dynamics, we  
 238 compared simulated post-extinction networks to observed networks using mean absolute  
 239 differences (MAD) for network-level metrics and true skills statistics (TSS) for node- and  
 240 link-level outcomes Figure 4. Across reconstruction approaches, MAD-based rankings were  
 241 generally positively correlated (Kendall’s  $\tau = 0.13$  across structural metrics), indicating  
 242 weak but generally positive concordance on the relative importance of extinction drivers  
 243 despite substantial differences in reconstructed network structure. However, agreement  
 244 within the allometric models differed from patterns observed for reconstructed network  
 245 structure.

246 Node-level TSS rankings were similarly consistent across network reconstruction approaches  
 247 (Kendall’s  $\tau = 0.26 - 0.90$ ), reflecting broadly comparable node-level removal sequences.  
 248 In contrast, link-level outcomes were far more variable (Kendall’s  $\tau = -0.48 - 0.29$ ),  
 249 highlighting that inferences about which interactions are lost, retained, or re-established  
 250 during collapse and recovery are highly reconstruction approach contingent. Together,  
 251 these results suggest that while alternative reconstruction approaches converge on similar  
 252 species-level extinction patterns, the inferred pathways of interaction loss and cascading  
 253 dynamics depend strongly on both reconstruction approaches.

254 [Figure 4 about here.]

## 4 Discussion

### 4.1 Network reconstruction is not neutral: structural priors shape ecological theory

Food web ecology has long treated network reconstruction as a technical step preceding ecological analysis. Once a network is assembled (whether from observation, inference, or simulation) its properties are typically analysed as reflections of underlying ecological organisation. Implicit in this workflow is a powerful assumption - that reconstructed networks provide structurally comparable representations of ecological communities, such that differences in connectance, trophic structure, motif composition, or robustness primarily reflect biological variation.

This assumption is particularly critical to evaluate within the context of deep-time palaeoecological data. Because interactions in fossil ecosystems are never observed directly, they must explicitly be formed through some form of reconstruction approach. This necessity renders the underlying assumptions transparent but also makes the resulting ecological narratives highly susceptible to the constraints inherent in the chosen reconstruction framework. In these settings the risk is not just incomplete data, but the potential for methodological artefacts to be misinterpreted as genuine macroevolutionary or palaeoecological signals. Consequently, deep-time studies offer a unique and stringent testing ground for determining whether community-level responses (such as stability or collapse during mass extinctions) are robust features of the ecosystem or merely byproducts of how we choose to construct the links between species.

Reconstruction framework explained the overwhelming majority of variance in inferred food web topology, far outweighing the influence of temporal turnover across extinction and recovery phases. Across an identical regional taxon pool, alternative reconstruction approaches generated distinct structural signatures that occupied non-overlapping regions of multivariate space Figure 1, demonstrating that divergence among reconstruction approaches reflects intrinsic differences in how interactions are organised rather than temporal shifts in community composition. Even after centring metrics within time bins (extinction phases) to remove between-bin mean differences, reconstruction approach remained the dominant driver of structural variation. These results indicate that reconstruction approaches impose distinct ‘structural priors’ on ecological inference. These priors are not subtle; they propagate into emergent topology, species roles, and predictions

287 of disturbance dynamics. Network structure is therefore not solely a property of ecological  
288 communities, but jointly determined by ecological data, reconstruction assumptions, and  
289 level of organisation (Gauzens *et al.*, 2025; Strydom *et al.*, 2026).

290 Crucially, this dominance was not confined to multivariate summaries. Variance partition-  
291 ing at the level of individual network properties revealed that reconstruction approach  
292 overwhelmingly structured specific ecological metrics, with partial  $r^2$  values exceeding  
293 0.9 for meso-scale motif composition and remaining consistently high across macro- and  
294 micro-scale properties. Thus the imprint of reconstruction framework is visible not only  
295 in aggregate topology but in the very structural features often interpreted as ecological  
296 signals — trophic height, competition, and variability in species roles. Notably, the  
297 few properties that exhibited detectable temporal sensitivity were also those with the  
298 greatest inter-reconstruction approach disagreement, indicating that temporal trends is  
299 most difficult to disentangle when reconstruction frameworks diverge most strongly. These  
300 results suggest that structural assumptions do not merely shift networks within a shared  
301 architectural space; they condition the specific patterns through which ecological change  
302 is perceived and interpreted.

303 This has direct implications for the interpretation of comparative network studies. Feasible,  
304 realised, and structural reconstruction approaches encode different assumptions about  
305 constraint, optimisation, and topology, with these assumptions propagating into emergent  
306 metrics and dynamical predictions (Dunne *et al.*, 2002; Curtsdotter *et al.*, 2011; Allesina  
307 & Tang, 2012; Poisot & Gravel, 2014; Michalska-Smith & Allesina, 2019). When networks  
308 reconstructed under different classes are compared across spatial gradients, disturbance  
309 regimes, or evolutionary transitions, part of the observed variation may derive from  
310 reconstruction choice rather than ecological process. Without explicit standardisation or  
311 sensitivity analysis, methodological heterogeneity can be mistaken for biological signal.  
312 Food web ecology has devoted substantial effort to understanding how topology shapes  
313 dynamics; comparatively less attention has been paid to how reconstruction method shapes  
314 topology. Our findings indicate that these two questions cannot be separated.

## 315 4.2 Scale-dependent robustness in network-based inference

316 Importantly, reconstruction sensitivity was not uniform across network scales (macro-,  
317 mesio-, micro- level properties). Node-level extinction rankings were broadly consis-  
318 tent among reconstruction approaches, whereas interaction-level outcomes and cascade

trajectories were highly contingent on reconstruction approach. The predominance of reconstruction framework over temporal turnover (~80% vs. 6% variance explained) illustrates why coarse-grained patterns like node-level extinction rankings are more robust. reconstruction approach-imposed structure dominates the overall topology, leaving interaction dynamics highly contingent on framework choice. This asymmetry reveals a context-dependent pattern of robustness. Coarse-grained macroecological patterns (such as the vulnerability of a community to collapse) can emerge from multiple plausible interaction architectures. By contrast, fine-grained inferences about which links are lost, retained, or reorganised depend strongly on how interactions are inferred.

This distinction challenges a central ambition of food web ecology: the use of detailed interaction structure to diagnose mechanisms of stability and collapse. Our findings suggest that while coarse-grained patterns might be shared across methods, fine-grained mechanistic narratives (such as the specific pathways of interaction loss) are much more precarious. This implies that had Dunhill *et al.* (2024) selected a different reconstruction method, the resulting inferences regarding the drivers of extinctions and subsequent recovery could have pointed to entirely different ecological mechanisms. If interaction-level cascade pathways vary substantially across equally plausible reconstructions, then mechanistic narratives derived from a single inferred topology may overstate their precision (Dunne *et al.*, 2002; Curtsdotter *et al.*, 2011; Allesina & Tang, 2012). The apparent determinism of extinction cascades may therefore partly reflect reconstruction-imposed structure rather than ecological inevitability.

For macroecology, this metric dependence clarifies where network-based inference is accurate. Aggregate properties may be comparatively robust to reconstruction assumptions, whereas conclusions about interaction turnover, motif reorganisation, or fine-scale trophic dynamics are intrinsically uncertain. Recognising this asymmetry is essential if network analyses are to inform comparative synthesis across space and time.

Taken together, these results underscore that network reconstruction is not a neutral preprocessing step but an additional part of the hypothesis-generating process in which each reconstruction approach encodes a distinct set of ecological assumptions. The inferred topology and dynamics of a food web therefore reflect not only ecological data, but the theoretical assumptions embedded in the reconstruction framework. Disagreement among reconstruction approaches does not imply that any single approach is ‘wrong’, but rather that different reconstruction approaches capture different facets of ecological reality

(Petchey *et al.*, 2011; Stouffer, 2019). Disagreement among reconstruction approaches does not imply that any single approach is ‘incorrect’. Rather, different reconstruction approaches capture different facets of ecological constraint—trait compatibility, energetic optimisation, or topological regularity. The critical point is that these facets are not interchangeable.

This perspective reframes reconstruction choice as part of hypothesis specification. Researchers must align reconstruction approaches with the ecological signals of interest (whether potential interactions, realised diets, or macro-scale structural properties) rather than treating network reconstruction as a technical convenience. Viewed through the lens of accuracy and precision, our results indicate that some network-based inferences are relatively robust across reconstruction approaches, whereas others remain intrinsically uncertain. High-level extinction rankings were broadly convergent, suggesting relative accuracy at coarse resolution, but interaction-level details and temporal cascade dynamics diverged substantially, indicating limited precision in reconstructing the fine structure of collapse. Recognising and explicitly accounting for this distinction is essential if food web ecology is to move beyond descriptive reconstruction toward rigorous comparative inference.

### 4.3 Implications for comparative biogeography and global change research

Network approaches are increasingly applied to examine how ecological organisation varies across latitudinal gradients, environmental filters, disturbance regimes, and climate-driven transitions (Tylianakis *et al.*, 2008; Gilman *et al.*, 2010). In global change ecology, networks are used to project vulnerability under warming, quantify rewiring of interactions, and assess stability under species loss (*e.g.*, Hao *et al.*, 2025; Marjakangas *et al.*, 2025). These studies frequently interpret variation in connectance, trophic height, interaction  $\beta$ -diversity, or robustness as indicators of ecological differentiation among regions or time intervals (*e.g.*, Pellissier *et al.*, 2018; Trøjelsgaard & Olesen, 2016). Our results show that such differences can systematically alter inferred topology and disturbance dynamics even when species composition is held constant. This suggests that apparent differences in network structure across spatial or climate gradients may reflect variation in reconstruction as much as ecological process.

Deep-time palaeo food webs provide a complementary perspective because they capture

ecosystem responses to large-scale environmental perturbations and extinction events under past climate change (*e.g.*, Dunhill *et al.* (2024); Karapınar *et al.* (2026); Smith *et al.* (2025)). Fossil networks therefore represent natural experiments for evaluating resilience, trophic reorganisation, and recovery following extreme environmental change. Studies of palaeo food webs have demonstrated how network structure mediates extinction cascades and post-disturbance reassembly (Roopnarine, 2006; Dunne *et al.*, 2008), providing empirical constraints on long-term ecological stability.

However, our results emphasise that even in deep-time systems structural conclusions remain sensitive to reconstruction approaches. Treating reconstructed networks as ensembles rather than single deterministic representations provides a more transparent framework for incorporating uncertainty into comparative macroecology and for using palaeo data to inform expectations about modern climate-driven reorganisation.

#### 4.4 Toward a more explicit modelling paradigm in food web ecology

The broader implication is not that any single reconstruction framework is ‘correct’ or ‘incorrect’. Rather, each reconstruction approach represents a distinct hypothesis about how interactions are constrained—by trait compatibility, energetic optimisation, or topological regularity (Petchey *et al.*, 2011). Food web reconstruction is therefore theory-laden. Making this explicit shifts reconstruction from a preparatory step to a central component of ecological modelling.

A mature modelling paradigm in food web ecology would treat reconstruction approaches as testable, incorporate probabilistic link inference where possible, and quantify the sensitivity of macroecological conclusions to alternative representations of interaction structure. Such an approach aligns with recent advances in probabilistic and ensemble network modelling and would strengthen the interpretability of network-based inference under global change (Poisot *et al.*, 2016; Banville *et al.*, 2025).

## 5 Conclusions

Ecological network reconstruction is not a neutral technical procedure but a theoretical act that shapes ecological inference. By applying six contrasting reconstruction frameworks to an identical species pool, we show that different reconstruction approaches systematically

influence inferred food web topology, interaction identity, and disturbance dynamics. Some coarse-grained patterns, such as relative species vulnerability, are comparatively robust across representations. In contrast, fine-scale interaction structure and cascade pathways are highly contingent on reconstruction approach. The reliability of network-based inference is therefore scale dependent.

These results challenge the implicit assumption that reconstructed networks are comparable across systems — whether comparing modern communities across environmental gradients or fossil assemblages across extinction intervals. When reconstruction frameworks differ, variation in connectance, trophic organisation, robustness, or interaction turnover may reflect embedded reconstruction approaches as much as ecological processes. Network reconstruction should thus be treated as an explicit component of hypothesis specification in comparative macroecology and biogeography.

No single reconstruction approach captures the full complexity of ecological organisation, but neither are alternative reconstruction approaches interchangeable. Aligning reconstruction framework with inferential goals, standardising approaches across comparative studies, and incorporating ensemble or probabilistic representations will be essential for strengthening the interpretability of network analyses across spatial and temporal gradients, including efforts to use deep-time systems to inform expectations under contemporary climate change. As ecological networks increasingly inform global change research, recognising network reconstruction as fundamental determinants of inference is critical for advancing food web ecology from descriptive reconstruction toward rigorous comparative synthesis.

## References

- Allesina, S. & Tang, S. (2012) [Stability criteria for complex ecosystems](#). *Nature*, **483**, 205–208.
- Bambach, R.K., Bush, A.M. & Erwin, D.H. (2007) [Autecology and the filling of ecospace: Key metazoan radiations](#). *Palaeontology*, **50**, 1–22.
- Banville, F., Strydom, T., Blyth, P.S.A., Brimacombe, C., Catchen, M.D., Dansereau, G., Higino, G., Malpas, T., Mayall, H., Norman, K., Gravel, D. & Poisot, T. (2025) [Deciphering probabilistic species interaction networks](#). *Ecology Letters*, **28**, e70161.
- Bezanson, J., Edelman, A., Karpinski, S. & Shah, V.B. (2017) [Julia: A fresh approach to numerical computing](#). *SIAM Review*, **59**, 65–98.

- 446 Brose, U., Jonsson, T., Berlow, E.L., Warren, P., Banasek-Richter, C., Bersier, L.-  
 447 F., Blanchard, J.L., Brey, T., Carpenter, S.R., Blandenier, M.-F.C., Cushing, L.,  
 448 Dawah, H.A., Dell, T., Edwards, F., Harper-Smith, S., Jacob, U., Ledger, M.E.,  
 449 Martinez, N.D., Memmott, J., Mintenbeck, K., Pinnegar, J.K., Rall, B.C., Rayner,  
 450 T.S., Reuman, D.C., Ruess, L., Ulrich, W., Williams, R.J., Woodward, G. & Cohen,  
 451 J.E. (2006) [Consumer–resource body-size relationships in natural food webs](#). *Ecology*,  
 452 **87**, 2411–2417.
- 453 Curtsdotter, A., Binzer, A., Brose, U., De Castro, F., Ebenman, B., Eklöf, A., Riede,  
 454 J.O., Thierry, A. & Rall, B.C. (2011) [Robustness to secondary extinctions: Comparing](#)  
 455 [trait-based sequential deletions in static and dynamic food webs](#). *Basic and Applied*  
 456 *Ecology*, **12**, 571–580.
- 457 Delmas, E., Besson, M., Brice, M.-H., Burkle, L.A., Dalla Riva, G.V., Fortin, M.-J.,  
 458 Gravel, D., Guimarães, P.R., Hembry, D.H., Newman, E.A., Olesen, J.M., Pires, M.M.,  
 459 Yeakel, J.D. & Poisot, T. (2018) [Analysing ecological networks of species interactions](#).  
 460 *Biological Reviews*, 112540.
- 461 Dunhill, A.M., Zarzyczny, K., Shaw, J.O., Atkinson, J.W., Little, C.T.S. & Beckerman,  
 462 A.P. (2024) [Extinction cascades, community collapse, and recovery across a mesozoic](#)  
 463 [hyperthermal event](#). *Nature Communications*, **15**, 8599.
- 464 Dunne, J.A., Labandeira, C.C. & Williams, R.J. (2014) [Highly resolved early eocene food](#)  
 465 [webs show development of modern trophic structure after the end-cretaceous extinction](#).  
 466 *Proceedings of the Royal Society B: Biological Sciences*, **281**, 20133280.
- 467 Dunne, J.A., Williams, R.J. & Martinez, N.D. (2002) Network structure and biodiversity  
 468 loss in food webs: Robustness increases with connectance. *Ecol. Lett.*, **5**, 558–567.
- 469 Dunne, J.A., Williams, R.J., Martinez, N.D., Wood, R.A. & Erwin, D.H. (2008) [Compila-](#)  
 470 [tion and network analyses of cambrian food webs](#). *PLOS Biology*, **6**, e102.
- 471 Erdős, P. & Rényi, A. (1959) [On random graphs. i](#). *Publicationes Mathematicae Debrecen*,  
 472 **6**, 290–297.
- 473 Fricke, E.C., Hsieh, C., Middleton, O., Gorczynski, D., Cappello, C.D., Sanisidro, O.,  
 474 Rowan, J., Svenning, J.-C. & Beaudrot, L. (2022) [Collapse of terrestrial mammal food](#)  
 475 [webs since the late pleistocene](#). *Science*, **377**, 1008–1011.
- 476 Fründ, J., McCann, K.S. & Williams, N.M. (2016) [Sampling bias is a challenge for](#)  
 477 [quantifying specialization and network structure: Lessons from a quantitative niche](#)  
 478 [model](#). *Oikos*, **125**, 502–513.
- 479 Gauzens, B., Brose, U., Delmas, E. & Berti, E. (2023) [ATNr: Allometric trophic network](#)

models in r. *Methods in Ecology and Evolution*, **14**, 2766–2773.

Gauzens, B., Thouvenot, L., Srivastava, D.S., Kratina, P., Romero, G.Q., Berti, E., O’Gorman, E.J., González, A.L., Dézerald, O., Eisenhauer, N., Pires, M., Ryser, R., Farjalla, V.F., Rogy, P., Brose, U., Petermann, J.S., Geslin, B. & Hines, J. (2025) [Tailoring interaction network types to answer different ecological questions](#). *Nature Reviews Biodiversity*, 1–10.

Gilman, S.E., Urban, M.C., Tewksbury, J., Gilchrist, G.W. & Holt, R.D. (2010) [A framework for community interactions under climate change](#). *Trends in Ecology & Evolution*, **25**, 325–331.

Gravel, D., Baiser, B., Dunne, J.A., Kopelke, J.-P., Martinez, N.D., Nyman, T., Poisot, T., Stouffer, D.B., Tylianakis, J.M., Wood, S.A. & Roslin, T. (2019) [Bringing elton and grinnell together: A quantitative framework to represent the biogeography of ecological interaction networks](#). *Ecography*, **42**, 401–415.

Guimarães, P.R. (2020) [The structure of ecological networks across levels of organization](#). *Annual Review of Ecology, Evolution, and Systematics*, **51**.

Hao, X., Holyoak, M., Zhang, Z. & Yan, C. (2025) [Global projection of terrestrial vertebrate food webs under future climate and land-use changes](#). *Global Change Biology*, **31**, e70061.

Jordano, P. (2016) [Sampling networks of ecological interactions](#). *Functional Ecology*.

Karapınar, B., Strydom, T., Beckerman, A.P., Ridgwell, A., Wignall, P.B., Dunne, J.A., Little, C.T.S., Hull, P., Pimiento, C. & Dunhill, A. (2026) [No global collapse of food webs across the permian-triassic mass extinction](#). *BioRxiv*.

Kemp, D.B., Han, Z., Hu, X., Chen, W., Jin, S., Izumi, K., Yan, Q., Baranyi, V., Jin, X., Corso, J.D. & Ge, Y. (2024) [Global hydroclimate perturbations during the toarcian oceanic anoxic event](#). *Earth-Science Reviews*, **258**, 104946.

Marjakangas, E.-L., Dalsgaard, B. & Ordonez, A. (2025) [Fundamental interaction niches: Towards a functional understanding of ecological networks’ resilience](#). *Ecology Letters*, **28**, e70146.

Michalska-Smith, M.J. & Allesina, S. (2019) [Telling ecological networks apart by their structure: A computational challenge](#). *PLOS Computational Biology*, **15**, e1007076.

Milo, R., Shen-Orr, S., Itzkovitz, S., Kashtan, N., Chklovskii, D. & Alon, U. (2002) [Network motifs: Simple building blocks of complex networks](#). *Science*, **298**, 824–827.

Morales-Castilla, I., Matias, M.G., Gravel, D. & Araújo, M.B. (2015) [Inferring biotic interactions from proxies](#). *Trends in Ecology & Evolution*, **30**, 347–356.

Pellissier, L., Albouy, C., Bascompte, J., Farwig, N., Graham, C., Loreau, M., Maglianesi,  
 M.A., Melián, C.J., Pitteloud, C., Roslin, T., Rohr, R., Saavedra, S., Thuiller, W.,  
 Woodward, G., Zimmermann, N.E. & Gravel, D. (2018) [Comparing species interaction  
 networks along environmental gradients](#). *Biological Reviews*, **93**, 785–800.

Petchey, O.L., Beckerman, A.P., Riede, J.O. & Warren, P.H. (2011) [Fit, efficiency, and  
 biology: Some thoughts on judging food web models](#). *Journal of Theoretical Biology*,  
**279**, 169–171.

Petchey, O.L., Beckerman, A.P., Riede, J.O. & Warren, P.H. (2008) [Size, foraging, and  
 food web structure](#). *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences*, **105**, 4191–4196.

Poisot, T., Bergeron, G., Cazelles, K., Dallas, T., Gravel, D., MacDonald, A., Mercier, B.,  
 Violet, C. & Vissault, S. (2021) [Global knowledge gaps in species interaction networks  
 data](#). *Journal of Biogeography*, jbi.14127.

Poisot, T., Canard, E., Mouillot, D., Mouquet, N. & Gravel, D. (2012) [The dissimilarity  
 of species interaction networks](#). *Ecology Letters*, **15**, 1353–1361.

Poisot, T., Cirtwill, A., Cazelles, K., Gravel, D., Fortin, M.-J. & Stouffer, D. (2016) [The  
 structure of probabilistic networks](#). *Methods in Ecology and Evolution*, **7**, 303312.

Poisot, T. & Gravel, D. (2014) [When is an ecological network complex? Connectance  
 drives degree distribution and emerging network properties](#). *PeerJ*, **2**, e251.

Poisot, T., Stouffer, D.B. & Gravel, D. (2015) [Beyond species: Why ecological interaction  
 networks vary through space and time](#). *Oikos*, **124**, 243–251.

R Core Team (2024) [R: A language and environment for statistical computing](#), R Foundation  
 for Statistical Computing, Vienna, Austria.

Rohr, R., Scherer, H., Kehrli, P., Mazza, C. & Bersier, L.-F. (2010) [Modeling food webs:  
 Exploring unexplained structure using latent traits](#). *The American Naturalist*, **176**,  
 170–177.

Roopnarine, P.D. (2006) [Extinction cascades and catastrophe in ancient food webs](#).  
*Paleobiology*, **32**, 1–19.

Sandra, H.-P., Traveset, A., Nogales, M., Heleno, R., Llewelyn, J. & Strona, G. (2025)  
[Sampling biases across interaction types affect the robustness of ecological multilayer  
 networks](#). *Ecological Informatics*, 103183.

Shaw, J.O., Dunhill, A.M., Beckerman, A.P., Dunne, J.A. & Hull, P.M. (2024) [A framework  
 for reconstructing ancient food webs using functional trait data](#). 2024.01.30.578036.

Smith, Q.A., Tomé, C.P., Gearty, W., Smith, F.A., Shizuka, D. & Lyons, S.K. (2025) [Con-  
 sequences of the megafauna extinction: Changes in food web networks on the edwards](#)

plateau across the pleistocene–holocene transition. *Global Ecology and Biogeography*,  
**34**, e70113.

Stouffer, D.B. (2019) All ecological models are wrong, but some are useful. *Journal of Animal Ecology*, **88**, 192–195.

Stouffer, D.B., Camacho, J., Jiang, W. & Nunes Amaral, L.A. (2007) Evidence for the existence of a robust pattern of prey selection in food webs. *Proceedings of the Royal Society B: Biological Sciences*, **274**, 1931–1940.

Strydom, T., Catchen, M.D., Banville, F., Caron, D., Dansereau, G., Desjardins-Proulx, P., Forero-Muñoz, N.R., Higino, G., Mercier, B., Gonzalez, A., Gravel, D., Pollock, L. & Poisot, T. (2021) A roadmap towards predicting species interaction networks (across space and time). *Philosophical Transactions of the Royal Society B: Biological Sciences*, **376**, 20210063.

Strydom, T., Dunhill, A.M., Dunne, J.A., Poisot, T. & Beckerman, A.P. (2026) Scaling from metawebs to realised webs: A hierarchical approach to network ecology. *EcoEvoRxiv*.

Thuiller, W., Calderón-Sanou, I., Chalmandrier, L., Gaüzère, P., O'Connor, L.M.J., Ohlmann, M., Poggiato, G. & Münkemüller, T. (2024) Navigating the integration of biotic interactions in biogeography. *Journal of Biogeography*, **51**, 550–559.

Trøjelsgaard, K. & Olesen, J.M. (2016) Ecological networks in motion: Micro- and macroscopic variability across scales. *Functional Ecology*, **30**, 1926–1935.

Tylianakis, J.M., Didham, R.K., Bascompte, J. & Wardle, D.A. (2008) Global change and species interactions in terrestrial ecosystems. *Ecology Letters*, **11**, 1351–1363.

Tylianakis, J.M. & Morris, R.J. (2017) Ecological networks across environmental gradients. *Annual Review of Ecology, Evolution, and Systematics*, **48**, 25–48.

Williams, R.J. & Martinez, N.D. (2000) Simple rules yield complex food webs. *Nature*, **404**, 180–183.

Williams, R.J. & Martinez, N.D. (2004) Stabilization of chaotic and non-permanent food-web dynamics. *The European Physical Journal B - Condensed Matter*, **38**, 297–303.

Williams, R.J. & Martinez, N.D. (2008) Success and its limits among structural models of complex food webs. *The Journal of Animal Ecology*, **77**, 512–519.

Yeakel, J.D., Pires, M.M., Rudolf, L., Dominy, N.J., Koch, P.L., Guimarães, P.R. & Gross, T. (2014) Collapse of an ecological network in ancient egypt. *PNAS*, **111**, 14472–14477.

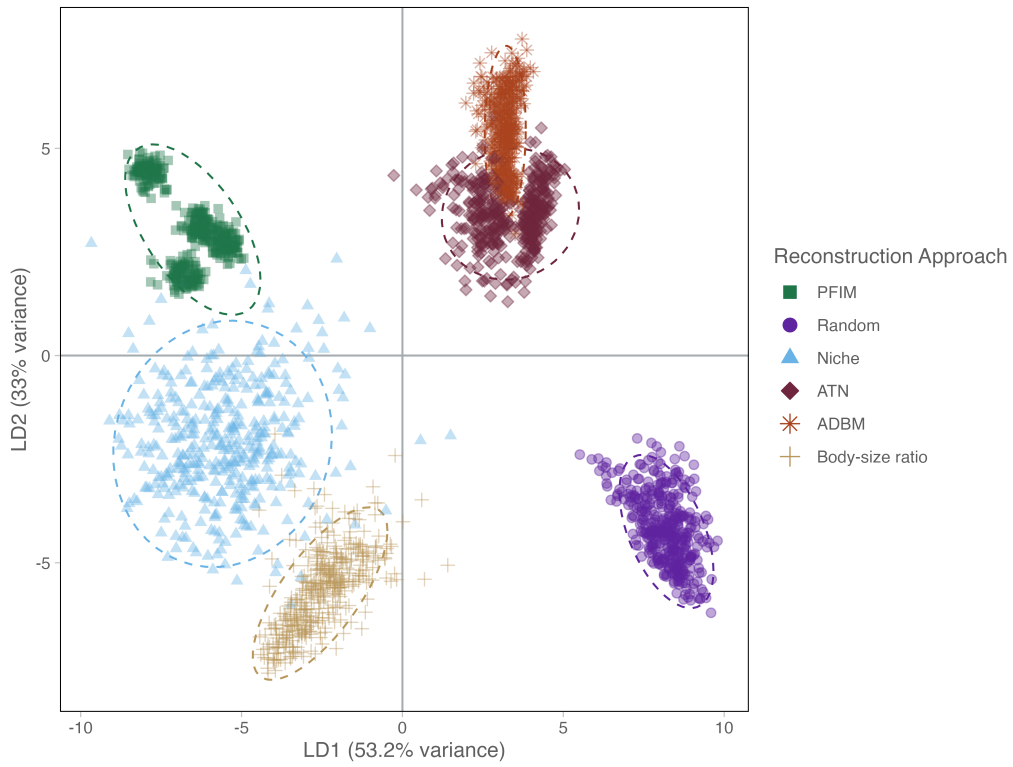


Figure 1: Linear discriminant analysis (LDA) of ecological network metrics for six reconstruction approach types. Each point represents a replicate, and ellipses indicate 95% confidence regions for each reconstruction approach. The second column represents the correlation of the various network metrics with the respective LDA axes.

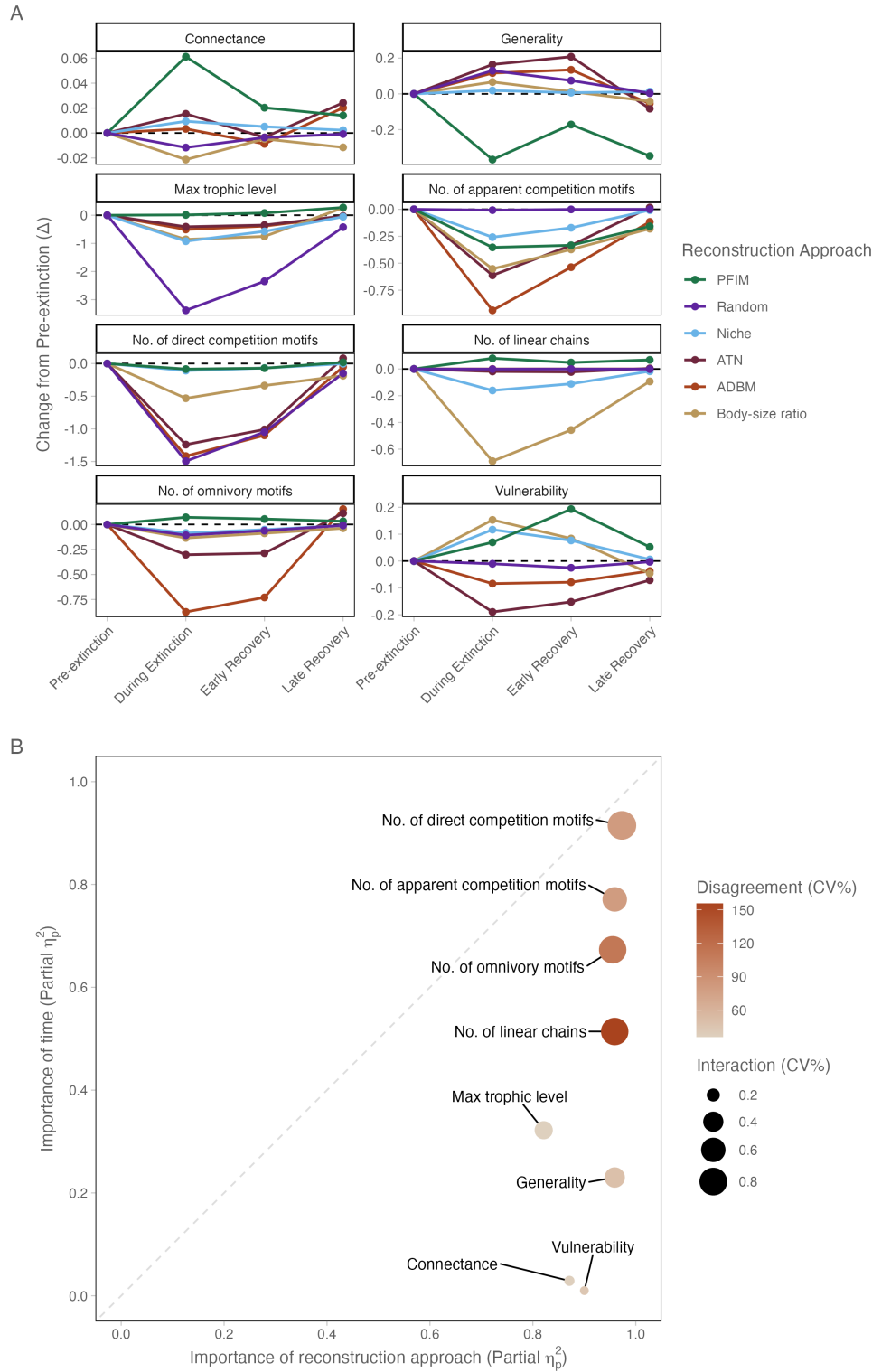


Figure 2: **A** Changes in network metrics through time, expressed as deviation from Pre-Extinction conditions ( $\Delta$ ). Metrics are faceted and scaled independently to highlight differences in temporal trajectories across different network properties. **B** Scatter plot illustrating the influence of reconstruction approach (x-axis) and time (y-axis) across network metrics. The dashed 1:1 diagonal represents parity of influence; metrics below this line are governed primarily by reconstruction approach and those above by time. Bubble size indicates the interaction between reconstruction approach and time, while colour indicates inter reconstruction approach disagreement (mean CV%); greener bubbles signify metrics where reconstruction approaches show the highest divergence in their structural predictions.

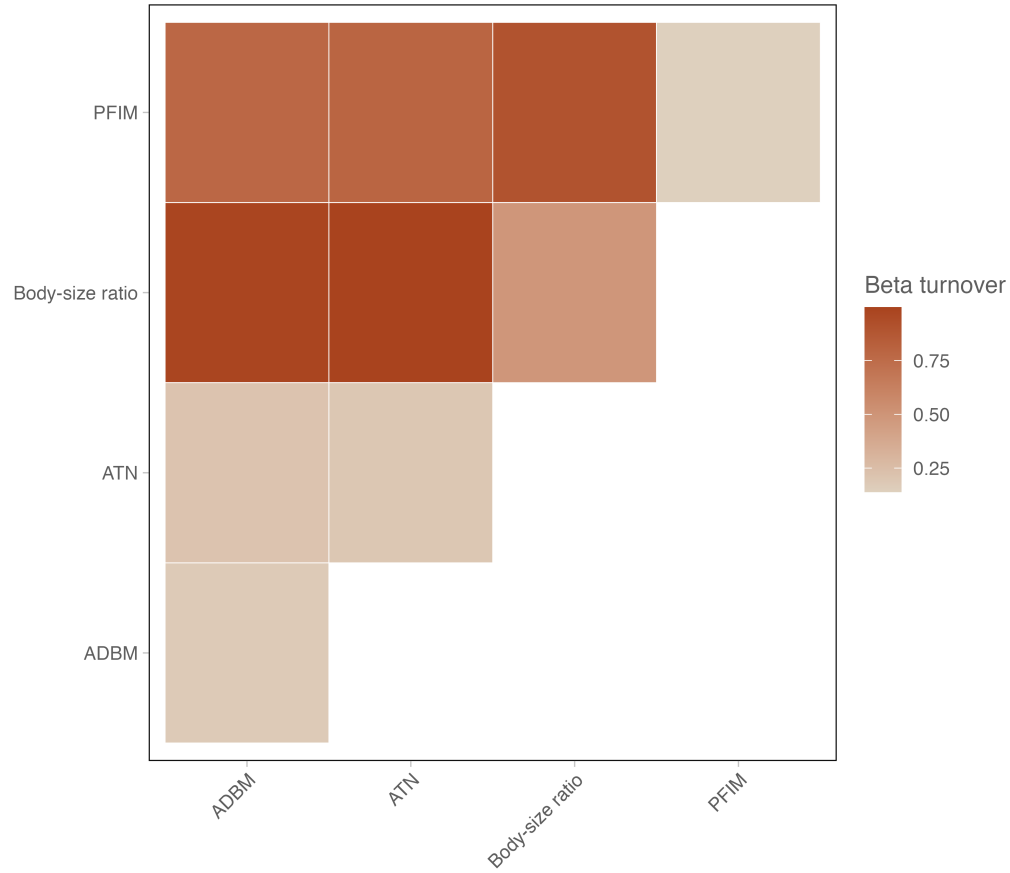


Figure 3: Pairwise  $\beta_{OS}$  in species interactions among four ecological network reconstruction approaches (ADBM, ATN, Body-size ratio, and PFIM). Each cell represents the mean turnover value between a pair of reconstruction approaches, with darker colours indicating greater dissimilarity in inferred interactions. High turnover values indicate strong disagreement in pairwise interactions between reconstruction approaches, whereas lower values indicate greater similarity. Note that we do not include the Random or Niche model as these reconstruction approaches are species agnostic and thus we cannot truly evaluate differences in pairwise interactions

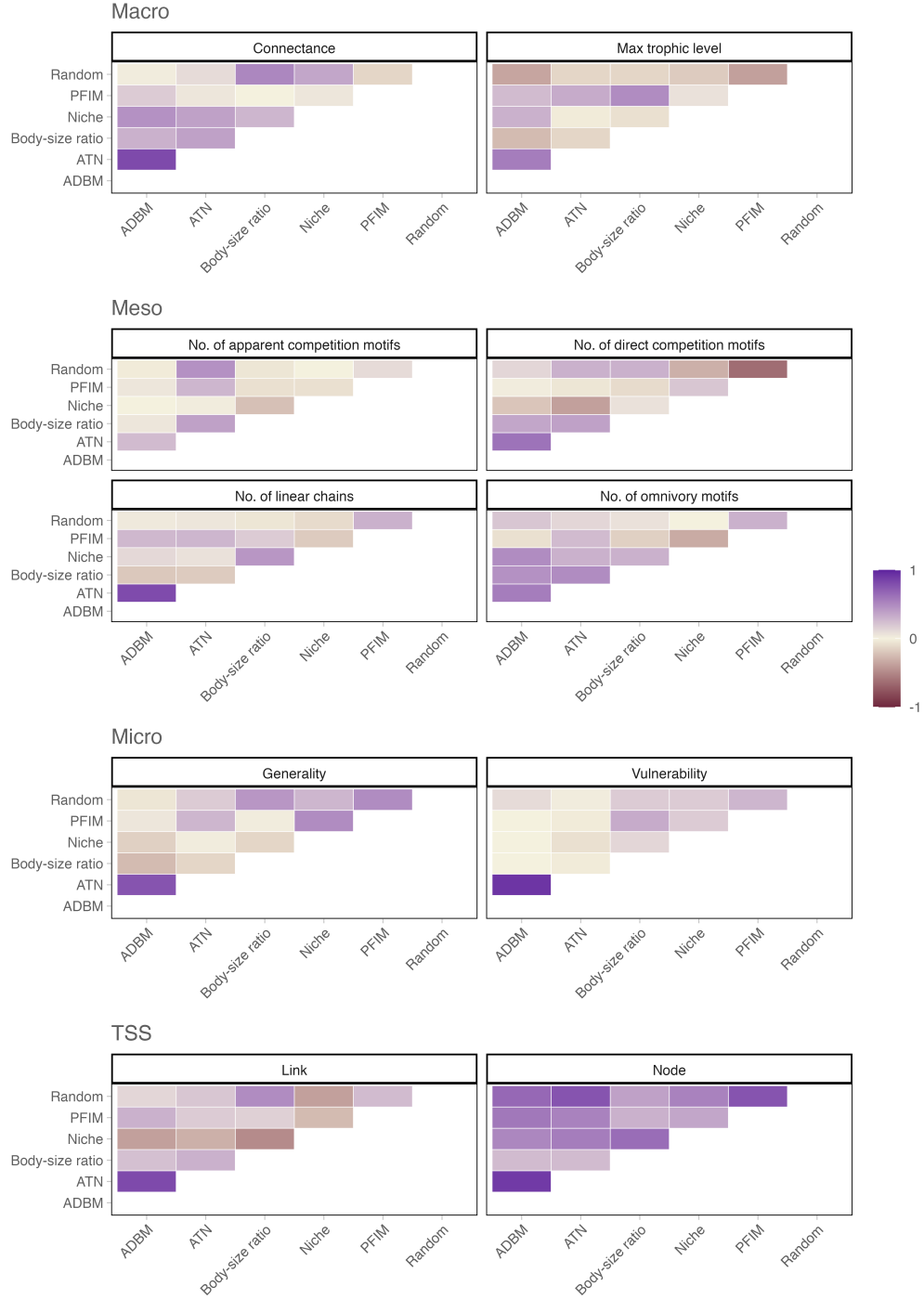


Figure 4: Heatmaps showing pairwise Kendall rank correlation coefficients ( $\tau$ ) between reconstruction approaches for each network metric. Each panel corresponds to a different metric and displays the degree of agreement in extinction-scenario rankings across reconstruction approaches based on mean absolute differences (MAD) between observed and predicted network values. Positive  $\tau$  values (purple) indicate concordant rankings between reconstruction approaches, whereas negative  $\tau$  values (sienna) indicate opposing rankings. Warmer colours approaching zero represent little or no agreement.